Character design bible — Episode 1: “3:07”

Working design and performance bible for Luis M. Minier’s Heralds of the Cemí. **Exploratory, not canonical identity approval.** This covers the full episode’s named cast, child variants and production ensembles; detailed visual delivery in this run is limited to Amaia/Dairon plus S01 boards.

Evidence and precedence

Current episode facts below come from `projects/cemi_episode_01/data/EPISODE_SCRIPT.md`, §2 cast and the cited shot IDs. Older details come from `research/earlier_cemi_pipeline/data/character_bible.txt` and remain subordinate. The original author pencil portraits were not supplied to this task; existing generated sheets are exploratory appearance references. This document does not certify historical costume authenticity or create new character canon.

Current `production/art_direction.json` overrides a generic anime finish: irregular hand ink, intentional hatching, painterly color and two or three cel planes. Preserve pigment under navy/steel shadow; warm amber is scene-motivated, not a global orange wash. BEFORE is moonless with child blue, unlike the warm neutral model-sheet inspection light.

Amaia · AMAIA

Coverage: BEFORE lead canoe; S01-02/03/13/14.

Episode facts: Mother carrying sleeping son; counts fourteen becoming eleven; turns with the current.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible: 26-year-old Taíno woman, gaunt, bronze-brown skin, wet tied-back long black hair, cotton wrap; red ochre explicitly an adaptation choice.

Proposed design: Worn ivory shoulder wrap, rust skirt, dark curls in low tied ponytail, angular brows. Separate supported-child pose from free-arm model.

Acting brief: Counting lips; guarded glance; protective brace; quiet turn. No triumphant combat pose for the escape.

Dairon · DAIRON

Coverage: BEFORE lead canoe; S01-02/08/09/12.

Episode facts: Paddles lead canoe; turns bow after seven-year-old’s instruction.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible: Amaia’s brother, about 30, lean/hard build, set jaw.

Proposed design: Dark low-tied curls, ivory asymmetric wrap and rust waist wrap following exploratory archival sheet; rigid wood paddle.

Acting brief: Reach/plant/pull/lift/recover; eyes find exit before torso commits; no explanatory line.

Yara · YARA

Coverage: BEFORE lead canoe; S01-02.

Episode facts: Sits behind Dairon holding cemí wrapped in stiff cloth against chest.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible names La Madre, age about 20 explicitly adaptation choice.

Proposed design: Two forearms enclose weathered bundle; distinct head silhouette from Amaia; costume/facial specifics pending.

Acting brief: Pressure of hands increases during turn; bundle never floats or becomes exposed without script authority.

Amaia's son · AMAIA-SON

Coverage: BEFORE lead canoe; S01-02/13.

Episode facts: Not yet two; asleep against ribs; speaks in a voice too old for him with eyes closed.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible: 22 months, round face, holds Yúcahu stone; current shot does not call for revealing that prop.

Proposed design: Compact toddler proportions; closed-eye mouth replacements; cotton contact folds.

Acting brief: Sleeping breath and tiny mouth motion; supported head and torso.

Beheto · BEHETO

Coverage: BEFORE second canoe; S01-02/11.

Episode facts: Drum between knees; chest whistles each breath; both palms press and weight leans into drum.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible: elderly Taíno man with sunken ribs, rattling chest.

Proposed design: Narrow rib silhouette; readable palms; drum ellipse and skull landmark anchors.

Acting brief: Laborious breath; low muscular weight transfer rather than a theatrical strike.

Girl of seven · GIRL-7

Coverage: BEFORE third canoe; S01-06/08.

Episode facts: One of three blue-lit children; tells water there is a way under roots.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible agrees age seven; identity not named.

Proposed design: Small, grounded child; separate skin, blue light and eyes.

Acting brief: Still certainty; lean follows detached blue; no smile of magical triumph.

Boy of nine · BOY-9

Coverage: BEFORE third canoe; S01-06/10.

Episode facts: Tilts head toward bell and distinguishes where they were from where they are.

Older reference, subordinate: Older bible says child of nine; current script specifies boy.

Proposed design: Older/taller than girl without adult anatomy; faint blue rim.

Acting brief: Listen before speaking; stable head tilt.

Smaller lit child · SMALL-CHILD

Coverage: BEFORE third canoe; S01-02/06.

Episode facts: Third of three lit children; blue breath on forearms and silent lean.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible says one smaller; exact age/name unspecified.

Proposed design: Clearly smaller silhouette; no invented age caption.

Acting brief: Silent shared pull with independent balance.

Ledger man · LEDGER-MAN

Coverage: BEFORE bank; S01-07/14.

Episode facts: On stump, ledger on knee, writes without looking, closes book.

Older reference, subordinate: Older bible uses colonial clerk/doublet/hat and a 1523 asset tag; date is not authorized for this episode.

Proposed design: Restrained dark costume silhouette; pen and binding remain legible; no invented symbols or text.

Acting brief: Small neat repeated marks; wrist economy; finish then close.

Bell soldier and torch soldiers · BELL-SOLDIER

Coverage: BEFORE bank; S01-05.

Episode facts: Soldiers stop; one raises brass bell on pole and rings it.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier pack is contextual reference only.

Proposed design: Bell shell/clapper/pole/holding hand separated; anonymous distant faces.

Acting brief: Firm lift; clapper lag; halted torch formation.

Absent passengers / memory children · LOST-PASSENGERS

Coverage: BEFORE memory; S01-03/04.

Episode facts: Pale empty-seat outlines; fevered children, lightning memory. Number and identity ambiguous.

Older reference, subordinate: No individual design identity approved.

Proposed design: Anonymous silhouettes only until counting discrepancy resolved.

Acting brief: Fade as Amaia looks; memory is fleeting, not an additional living cast.

Juan Carlos / JC · JC

Coverage: Present lead; S03–S15.

Episode facts: 25, Bronx sound artist/barista/AR muralist; hoodie; contact mic, laptop, earbud, warm copper coin; defensive humor.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible: Cabral, lean; short curls/fade, stubble, 5 ft 9, light-brown pigment and charcoal hoodie are proposed adaptation choices.

Proposed design: Tired angular face, restless tapping fingers; distinguish headphones around neck from single working earbud per shot.

Acting brief: Observe → joke/deflect → involuntary bodily warning → reluctant deliberate listening. No later-novel wounds or hearing loss.

Mamá · MAMA

Coverage: Present family; S06/07; S14 memory.

Episode facts: Rosary in fist, slippers, two-knock pattern; knows keyboard stopped 3:07; offers food and guarded warning.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible: Altagracia Cabral, 53; sturdy build and detailed palette are adaptation choices.

Proposed design: Pulled-back hair, practical blouse, towel; costume remains domestic in kitchen.

Acting brief: Still stare carries sentence; rosary clicks independently of talking.

Manny · MANNY

Coverage: Present friend; S03 texts; S10–12.

Episode facts: 6 ft 3, broad dancer's build; friend since nine; drum case/sticks; palm makes six noises fall together.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible: Manuel, Afro-Dominican, 25; haircut, tee/pants/colors are adaptation choices.

Proposed design: Huge rounded shoulders and clear hand silhouettes; easy grin; no later taped ribs.

Acting brief: Loose entrance; unaware grounding palm; careful hand-to-shoulder intervention when JC blanks.

Sofía · SOFIA

Coverage: Present researcher; S11 texts; S13/14.

Episode facts: Tenant-association researcher; laptop and many tabs; calls JC bobo; seeks a measurable control.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible proposes about 26, claw clip, rectangular glasses, cardigan.

Proposed design: Quick economical silhouette; glasses/claw clip optional proposals, not required likeness facts.

Acting brief: Hovers hand, opens laptop before sitting; prosecutes facts; half-closes laptop when fear becomes personal.

Mr. Rodríguez · RODRIGUEZ

Coverage: Present café; S09/12/14.

Episode facts: Owner/poet; expressive inherited eyebrows; butcher-paper map and cards; refuses supplied speaker.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible: about 70, stocky and clean-shaven are partly adaptation choices; father has mustache.

Proposed design: Apron, rolled sleeves, rag; eyebrow masses readable at medium scale.

Acting brief: Eyebrow joke; practical concern crosses room before explanation.

Abuela · ABUELA

Coverage: Voice / memory hands; S00/03-06/13-06.

Episode facts: Epigraph voice; gives coin in fever memory; stops young JC reaching bundle. Face withheld by explicit source adaptation.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible contains complete face and later-era variants; they do not authorize a reveal here.

Proposed design: Hand reference, housedress cuff and cloth bundle only; no face asset required.

Acting brief: Quick but gentle wrist stop; returns tenderness with mango.

Adrian Vale · VALE

Coverage: Email and photographs; S11/14.

Episode facts: Tall, gray, courteous, good coat; small black notebook in every photograph; named email signatory.

Older reference, subordinate: Older bible details mid-fifties, pale skin and gray eyes partly as choices; no live scene requested.

Proposed design: Still-photo design with coat and notebook; exact photo continuity.

Acting brief: Courteous photo posture; notebook rhyme does not establish identity with earlier counters.

Man in window · WINDOW-MAN

Coverage: Silhouette; S06/12-07/15-08.

Episode facts: Headphones, third-floor window across street; deliberately unidentified; brief eight-frame double exposure.

Older reference, subordinate: Later-novel naming in older bible is excluded from Episode 1 design.

Proposed design: Opaque backlit figure; no recognizable facial reveal or name tag.

Acting brief: Still watching geometry only; preserve ambiguity.

Yari · YARI

Coverage: Phone/UI only; S10-05.

Episode facts: Texts asking whether JC ate; relationship not stated in episode.

Older reference, subordinate: Older bible's relationship/revealed profession excluded here.

Proposed design: Exact screen text; no invented portrait/avatar.

Acting brief: Message pacing carries concern.

Denise · DENISE

Coverage: Text / text-read voice; S13-03.

Episode facts: Milestone-payment hold message, cheerful corporate phrasing.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible cardigan/arts-space details need no physical design for this episode.

Proposed design: Exact UI message, no face asset.

Acting brief: Chirpy read if recorded, in tension with content.

JC age twelve · JC-12

Coverage: Coin memory; S03-06.

Episode facts: Fever, asleep, dirt under fingernails; grandmother sets coin in hand.

Older reference, subordinate: Do not import later injuries.

Proposed design: Age-adjusted proportions retaining proposed family landmarks.

Acting brief: Sleep weight and hand receiving coin.

JC age eight · JC-8

Coverage: Santo Domingo memory; S13-06; S14-10.

Episode facts: Reaches for wrapped bundle; childhood wall-listening memory.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible oversized cap is a proposal, not required indoors.

Proposed design: Child counterpart with stable head landmarks.

Acting brief: Curiosity, halted reach, acceptance of mango; later laughs at wall.

JC age six · JC-6

Coverage: Classroom memory; S14-08.

Episode facts: Taps desk leg while room presses flat; screening level two.

Older reference, subordinate: Same character at distinct age; no adult styling.

Proposed design: Small schoolchild; tapping hand retains color in PRESS.

Acting brief: Body held while hand pushes back in rhythm.

Mikey age eight · MIKEY-8

Coverage: Stairwell memory; S14-10.

Episode facts: Fourth-floor child puts ear to wall and says Listen; associated with the three.

Older reference, subordinate: Adult scar/jacket blankness from later bible not imported automatically into child.

Proposed design: Age-specific unapproved design; clear ear-to-wall contact.

Acting brief: Patient listening held longer than a joke.

JC's father · FATHER

Coverage: Classroom/kitchen memory; S14-08.

Episode facts: Reads school letter standing with careful electric-bill expression; says Nivel dos.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible working man in thirties/work shirt marked adaptation.

Proposed design: Guarded face and modest work shirt proposal.

Acting brief: Read before speaking; contained concern.

Teacher and lanyard observer · SCHOOL-ADULTS

Coverage: Classroom memory; S14-08.

Episode facts: Teacher records tapping; woman with lanyard watches with clipboard.

Older reference, subordinate: Unnamed, exact appearances not supplied.

Proposed design: Separate teacher and observer silhouettes; clipboard retains source showcase saturation exception.

Acting brief: Writing/counting actions stay precise and restrained.

Classroom children · CLASSMATES

Coverage: Classroom memory; S14-08.

Episode facts: Heads down at quiet time.

Older reference, subordinate: No names or exact class size supplied.

Proposed design: Small varied schoolchild bank; no cloned faces.

Acting brief: PRESS reduces acting cadence; do not animate a party of reactions.

1973 counterman · COUNTERMAN-1973

Coverage: Record-shop Echo; S12-05/06.

Episode facts: Mustache, good shirt, Mr. Rodríguez's eyebrows; asks about two identical records.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible identifies father and about 45; current shot supports visual family rhyme.

Proposed design: Period shirt and mustache; match eyebrow shape only, not entire head.

Acting brief: Amused head shake while receiving quarters.

Crate kid · CRATE-KID

Coverage: 1973 Echo; S12-06/07.

Episode facts: 15 or 16, shell-toe Adidas, milk crate, two copies of one record; Todavía no. Do not name historical figure.

Older reference, subordinate: Older bible concurs.

Proposed design: Teen silhouette with crate supported on hip; keep two record sleeves identical.

Acting brief: Pay, receive, leave; determined understatement.

Thin notebook man · THIN-MAN

Coverage: 1973 Echo; S12-07.

Episode facts: Thin, brown suit, small notebook; buys nothing; tracks kid then looks at future JC.

Older reference, subordinate: Earlier bible gives a name not revealed in episode; do not label him as Vale or window man.

Proposed design: Sharp still posture distinct from gray modern coat.

Acting brief: Quick neat mark, following gaze, precise eye-lock.

1957 dancers and band · BALLROOM

Coverage: Ballroom Echo; S05.

Episode facts: About forty couples, two-tone shoes, flared skirts, horn section, unhurried cowbell, laughing woman.

Older reference, subordinate: Anonymous ensemble.

Proposed design: Three couples need hero interaction banks; varied silhouettes for crowd; transmitted-light planes, no cast shadows.

Acting brief: Alive partnered rhythms → missed steps → slack hands/empty faces → light runs away.

Café baby, stroller, two fans and freelancer · CAFE-ENSEMBLE

Coverage: Present café; S09/10/12.

Episode facts: Squeaky stroller, baby sighs; two Yankees debaters; freelancer typing and later staring.

Older reference, subordinate: Unnamed.

Proposed design: Distinct adult silhouettes and safe seated infant; minimal crowd banks.

Acting brief: Six independent sound sources fall into groove, then witness JC's absence.

Snoring Mets fan · METS-MAN

Coverage: Present library; S13.

Episode facts: Man in Mets jacket snores in long phrases.

Older reference, subordinate: Unnamed.

Proposed design: Slumped but supported seated silhouette; jacket identity via controlled post detail.

Acting brief: Chest/snore cycle fits chord without comical body inflation.

1934 library ensemble · READING-ROOM

Coverage: Reading-room Echo; S13-09/10.

Episode facts: Grandfather with Yiddish paper; two Irish girls/apple/penknife; porter; Puerto Rican mother and two children; two boys/map/eraser; librarian with spectacles chain.

Older reference, subordinate: No individual names or precise ages beyond boy/girl/grandfather.

Proposed design: Separate readable groups and hand props; avoid caricature as ethnicity shorthand.

Acting brief: Lips, apple handoff, finger under text, guiding collars, borrowed eraser, stamp/pencil hop each occupy independent sound lanes.

Three bodega men · BODEGA-MEN

Coverage: Present sidewalk; S15.

Episode facts: Two domino players and third intervening man; anger drains, no apology, third returns inside.

Older reference, subordinate: Do not silently identify any as Don Chino.

Proposed design: Three distinct silhouettes/hand poses with reusable PRESS counterparts.

Acting brief: Tile slap → argument → louder interruption → flattened exhaustion.

Daylight workers · STREET-WORKERS

Coverage: Present street; S08-03.

Episode facts: Daylight-only union shift; answer JC's question about nights.

Older reference, subordinate: Unnamed.

Proposed design: Practical workwear/tools only as layout proposals.

Acting brief: Ordinary unhurried answer contrasts JC's suspicion.

Present-day anecdote / flash figures · VIGNETTES

Coverage: Montage inserts; S03-02/04/12; S10-02; S11-05/06; S14-02/06.

Episode facts: Conductor/sandwich gag; trumpet player on six heard; scratch-off fighters; estranged men; super/dog/delivery worker; childhood friend vignettes; hidden curb-sleeve protector; Honda-seller flash; landlord; speaker sales rep.

Older reference, subordinate: Keep figures anonymous unless source specifically names them.

Proposed design: Shot-sized silhouettes or cropped contact hands; avoid inventing detailed backstories/portraits.

Acting brief: Each appears only to deliver its source gag or memory. Protector's face stays hidden.

Mentioned / paper-only people · MENTIONED

Coverage: Offscreen references; S07/09/10/13–15.

Episode facts: Doña Fela, Don Chino, Rafa, the kid whose EP is discussed, lady on three, and historical map names are references; no additional live scenes authorized.

Older reference, subordinate: Novel-wide bible contains many later characters omitted from this episode pack intentionally.

Proposed design: Names/text and story-associated props only unless shot explicitly requires a figure.

Acting brief: No unscripted dialogue, cameos or later-novel disclosures.

Amaia model and puppet construction brief

Directly inspected `research/archive_imports/river_2026_10_11/Cemi-River-Scene/01-Characters/01-Amaia.png`: front, profile, back, wide reaching pose and three face expressions. Visible features are warm bronze pigment, long dark textured curls tied low with pale cloth, strong brows, ivory shoulder wrap, rust skirt with ragged layered hems and bare feet. These are observations of an exploratory sheet, not proof of Luis's pencil likeness. The sheet's athletic body and dramatic reaching action should be reconciled against the older bible's gauntness and this scene's exhausted restraint, not silently treated as final.

For the new sheet: align eye line, chin, shoulders, waist, knees and soles across front / three-quarter / profile / back views. Supply neutral, counting, alarm-contained, grief and protective-focus heads at the same skull scale. Preserve curl mass rather than drawing random different strands each pose. The sheet's wrap coverage changes between views; choose a coherent seam/overlap map only as a marked proposal and route it for approval. Do not mirror an asymmetrical costume to obtain the opposite view.

For a digital cutout: body root at pelvis, torso, neck, fixed-volume head, separate eye/brow/mouth replacements, back-hair/front-hair, upper/lower arms, hands, wrap folds and skirt hem. Child support pose needs a dedicated shoulder/elbow/hand drawing and a child layer with contact anchors at Amaia's ribs and forearm. Maintain overlap padding inside joints. Eye blink and mouth changes can use replacements; turning, bracing and reaching require new drawings. A layered puppet file is a setup deliverable, not evidence that those actions animate.

Dairon model and puppet construction brief

Directly inspected `research/archive_imports/river_2026_10_11/Cemi-River-Scene/01-Characters/03-Dairon.png`: front, profile, back, forceful paddle action and face expressions. Visible features are textured low-tied black curls, strong jaw/brows, muscular arms, ivory diagonal wrap, rust ragged waist wrap, bare feet and a broad wood paddle. These are exploratory observations. Keep him lean/hard in accordance with the older description rather than increasing the sheet's heroic musculature. His hairstyle and clothing are very close to Amaia's in this archive; approve distinct face landmarks before canonical use.

New turnarounds must maintain shoulder width, nose/profile, jaw, hair tie height, hem edges and foot length. Expression bank: quiet resolve, glance toward roots, strain with closed jaw, release of effort, urgent listening. Shouting face is a model range sample only; no shouted S01 dialogue is supplied.

Rig paddle as a rigid separate asset with handle and blade landmarks. Define two contact anchors in

each drawn grip pose; hands never slide on the shaft during the pull. Bind hand placement to drawn contact rather than rubber arms. Provide registered reach, entry, loaded pull, trailing blade, lift, drip and recovery drawings. Hull and water remain independent. After S01-09, obtain approval for which paddle snapped before drawing the next intact paddle cycle.

Shared production sheet requirements

Every sheet carries character ID, variant, take, source references and exploratory status in editorial margins; scene art has no generated labels. A pose library stores full-canvas PNGs with transparent background, common origin, integer exposure proposals and registration landmarks. Keep skin swatches under neutral viewing light separate from scene lighting; proposed ivory/rust garments are not a mandated universal Taíno costume. Stage characters as specific individuals rather than interchangeable “tribal” costumes or stock anime faces.

Hero close-ups need face/hand contact review at final output scale. Background banks need readable variation and correct ages. Full episode cast coverage in this bible does not imply finished model sheets or puppets for every role.